

Urban studies



Program for today

Introduction to urban studies

Working methods of the course



What are urban studies about?

Stanford University

What is Urban Studies? An interdisciplinary, undergraduate program at Stanford that combines academic approaches with real-world experience to understand cities. If you've ever wondered why people live in cities (or suburbs), how the physical environment influences behavior, or how to address seemingly intractable problems like urban poverty, homelessness, or troubled schools, Urban Studies may be for you. Please see 15/16 bulletin and Urban Studies website for more info.



This transdisciplinary program builds on insights from critical urban geography, urban planning and architectural history.

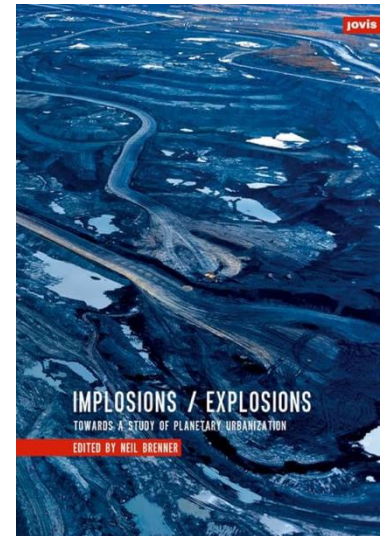
Urban Studies prepares you for a career in planning, public policy and community advocacy. Our alumni work as urban designers in the private sector, as planners in public administration (municipal, regional and state-level), and as consultants in the NGO sector. They have founded advocacy organizations, and many are active as urban activists. The program provides a good basis for postgraduate study.

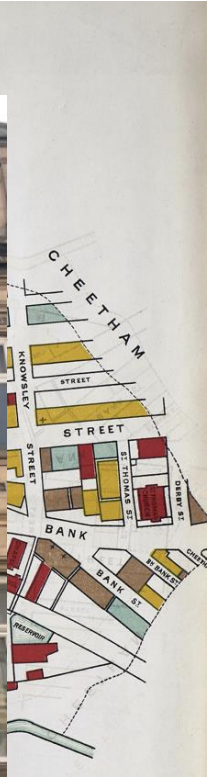
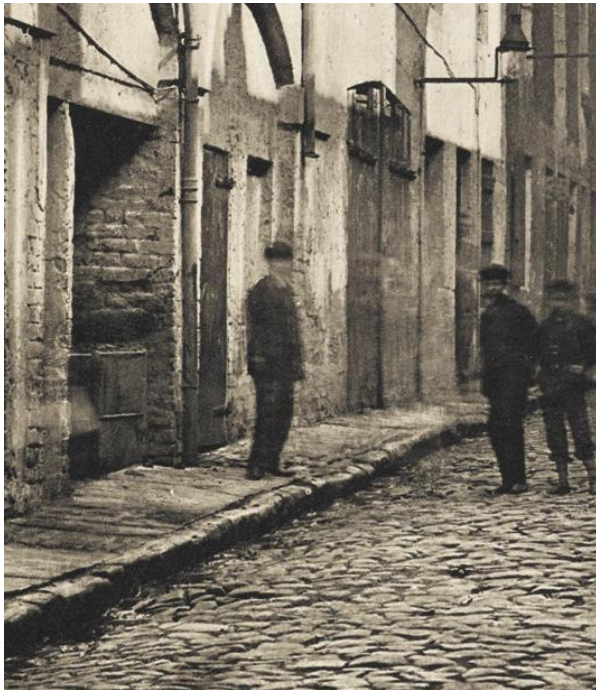
Brenner & Schmid 2021: Planetary urbanism

Framework for understanding urbanization not just as a localized phenomenon within individual cities but as a global process that shapes and is shaped by broader socio-economic and political forces.

Urbanization is global and occurs everywhere, on urban and rural scale, and is driven by global economic forces such as capitalism, neoliberalism, and globalization.

Urbanization is a “terrain of struggle”, struggle over land, housing, environmental justice, access to basic services etc. Therefore we should understand the agency of various social groups in shaping urban futures.





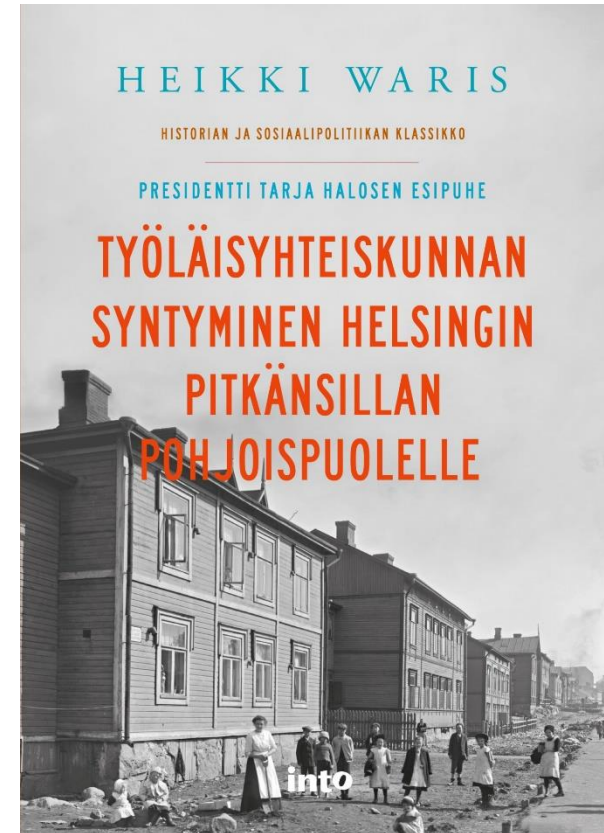
Frederick Engels for his
the Working-Class in E

- Life expectancy, 2

The birth of urban studies

Miserable conditions in cities: mapping,
action

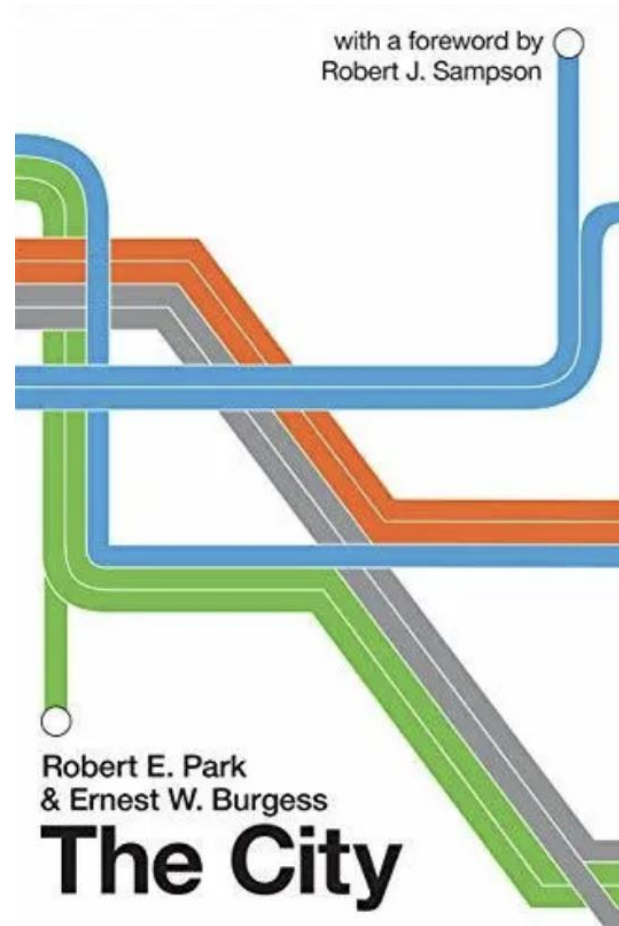
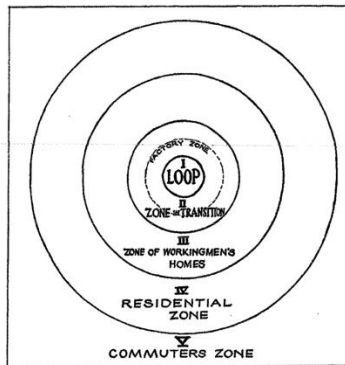
Anti-urban bias



The Chicago School

Urban development is driven by competition for space and the choices of individuals

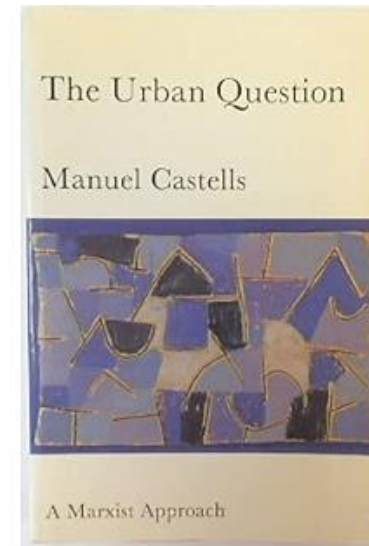
Defined the American city as unequal and segregated



1970s

Competition for space and the choices of individuals are not the characteristics of a city, but characteristics of a specific city -) the capitalist city

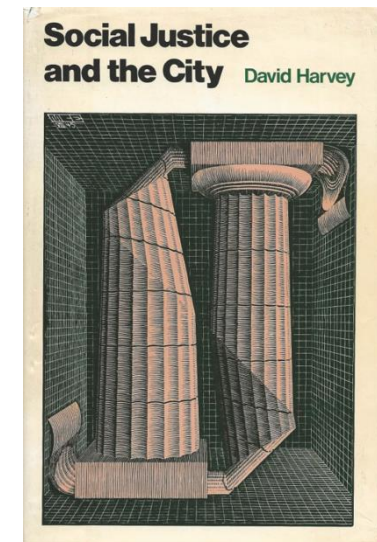
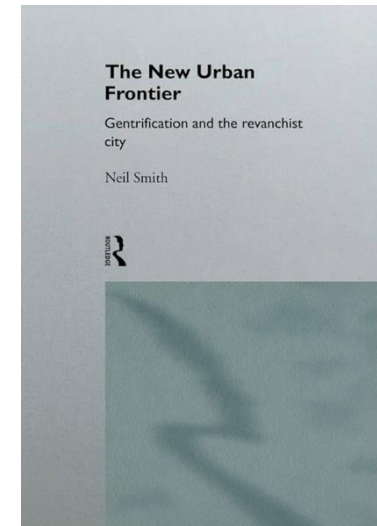
The Chicago theory was useful for the political elite who could claim that what happens is natural, and not about societal issues or class relations



1970s

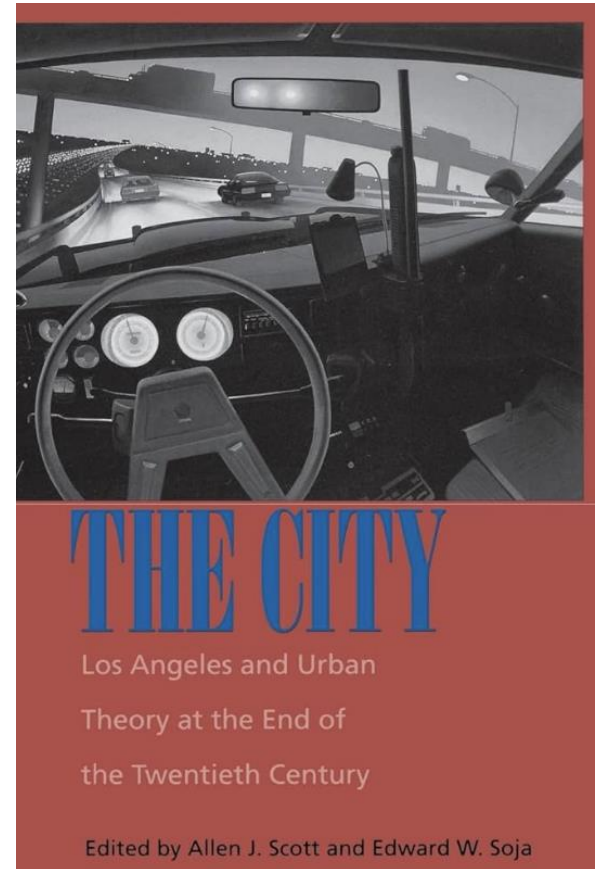
The Chicago school naturalized the unequal city.

Cities are segregated, but spatial inequality is not a consequence of competition between population groups, but of the politics of the state and city, the power of landowners and the profit-seeking of developers.



Los Angeles School

Fragmented, polycentric,
decentralized, multi-ethnic, controlled,
fortified

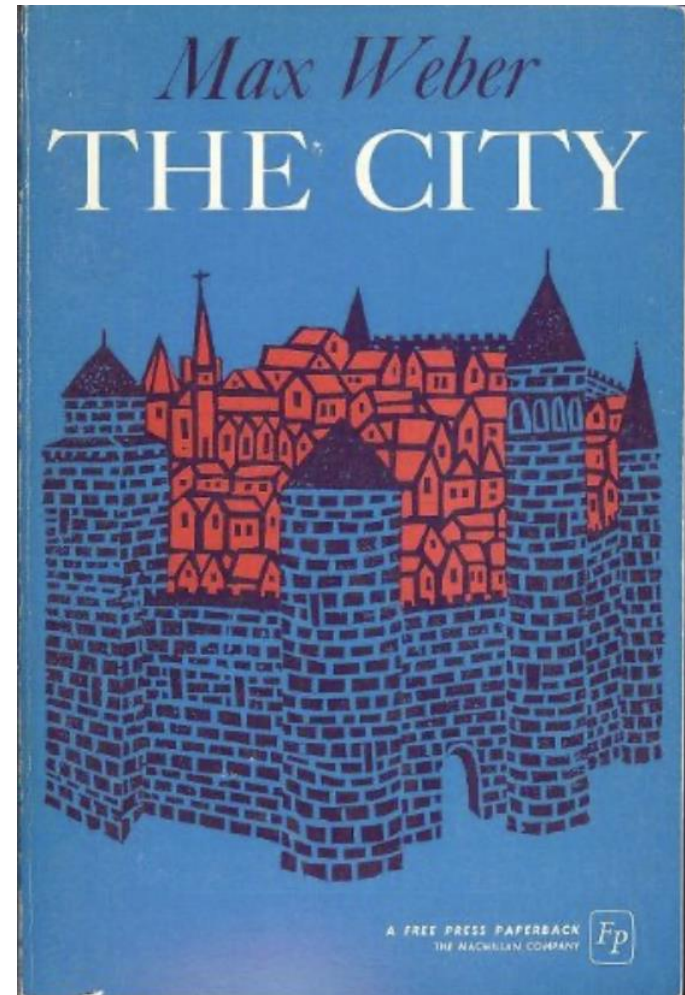


Weber 1921

The European city, in its historical development in the West, is a unique social and political entity characterized by a distinct form of community, autonomy, and economic activity.

The city is a driver of cultural, political, and economic transformation, plays a central role in the emergence of Western civilization.

The market, own laws, autonomy, a sort of associations of urban residents (versus Asian cities).

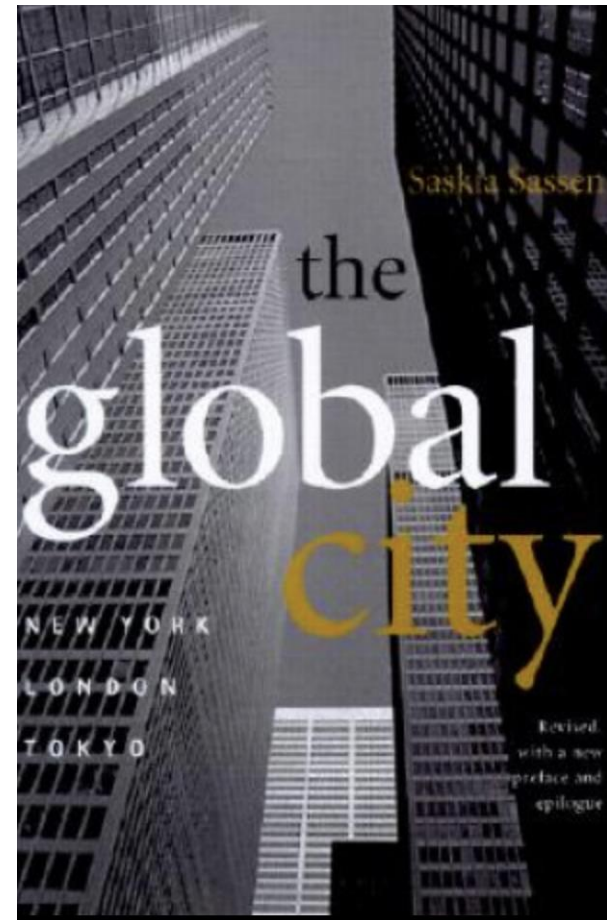


Sassen 1991

Globalisation as a savour of the autonomy of cities.

Certain cities (New York, London, and Tokyo) have become central hubs for global economic activity in the late 20th and early 21st centuries, playing a crucial role in managing, coordinating, and driving globalization.

These cities are not just centers of wealth and power but also sites of profound inequality and social transformation.





Simmel 1903

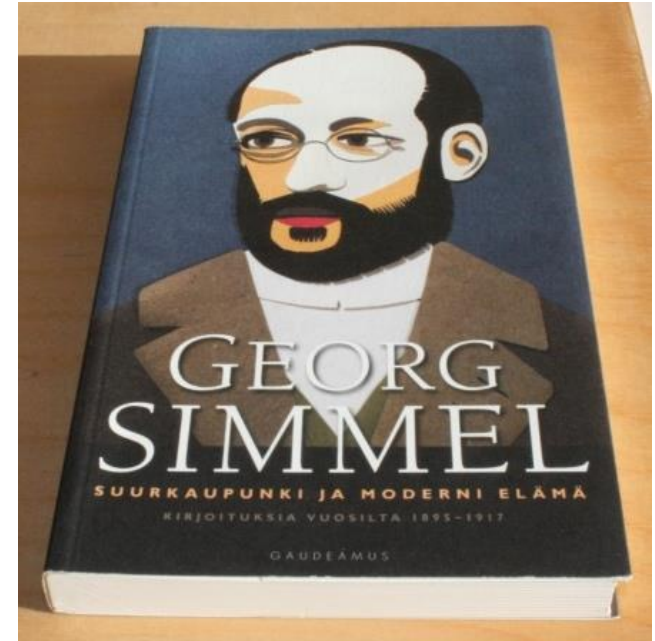
The Metropolis and Mental Life

An essay of urbanism as a way of life and personality -) Life in a modern city profoundly influences individual psychology and social relationships

Urban environments foster a distinct mental attitude, shaped by the rapid pace, density, and complexity of city life

Rural life: combination of meaningful relationships, established over time which cannot be established in the metropolis (anonymity, number of vendors...) -) city dweller can only establish a relationship with currency and money and exchange becomes the medium within which the city dweller invests their trust

Blasé attitude



Wirth 1938

Anonymity and Impersonal Relationships: In cities, individuals tend to have more superficial, impersonal, and transient relationships due to the large population size and the diverse, dispersed social networks.

Specialization and Division of Labor: Urban environments foster specialized roles and occupations, leading to economic interdependence among individuals and groups.

Cultural Diversity: Urban areas bring together people of varied backgrounds, resulting in cultural heterogeneity. This promotes tolerance, but may also lead to social fragmentation and conflict.

Behavioral Adaptations: Urban residents develop a more rational, calculated, and goal-oriented approach to life, often sacrificing traditional or community-based ties for individualism.

Weakened Social Ties: Urbanism is associated with a decline in close-knit community relationships, as people prioritize professional or personal ambitions over communal bonds.

THE AMERICAN JOURNAL OF SOCIOLOGY

VOLUME XLIV

JULY 1938

NUMBER 1

URBANISM AS A WAY OF LIFE

LOUIS WIRTH

ABSTRACT

The urbanization of the world, which is one of the most impressive facts of modern times, has wrought profound changes in virtually every phase of social life. The recency and rapidity of urbanization in the United States accounts for the acuteness of our urban problems and our lack of awareness of them. Despite the dominance of urbanism in the modern world we still lack a sociological definition of the city which would take adequate account of the fact that while the city is the characteristic locus of urbanism, the urban mode of life is not confined to cities. For sociological purposes a city is a relatively large, dense, and permanent settlement of heterogeneous individuals. Large numbers account for individual variability, the relative absence of intimate personal acquaintanceship, the segmentalization of human relations which are largely anonymous, superficial, and transitory, and associated characteristics. Density involves diversification and specialization, the coincidence of close physical contact and distant social relations, glaring contrasts, a complex pattern of segregation, the predominance of formal social control, and accentuated friction, among other phenomena. Heterogeneity tends to break down rigid social structures and to produce increased mobility, instability, and insecurity, and the affiliation of the individuals with a variety of intersecting and tangential social groups with a high rate of membership turnover. The pecuniary nexus tends to displace personal relations, and institutions tend to cater to mass rather than to individual requirements. The individual thus becomes effective only as he acts through organized groups. The complicated phenomena of urbanism may acquire unity and coherence if the sociological analysis proceeds in the light of such a body of theory. The empirical evidence concerning the ecology, the social organization, and the social psychology of the urban mode of life confirms the fruitfulness of this approach.

I. THE CITY AND CONTEMPORARY CIVILIZATION

Just as the beginning of Western civilization is marked by the permanent settlement of formerly nomadic peoples in the Mediterranean basin, so the beginning of what is distinctively modern in our civilization is best signalized by the growth of great cities. Nowhere has mankind been farther removed from organic nature

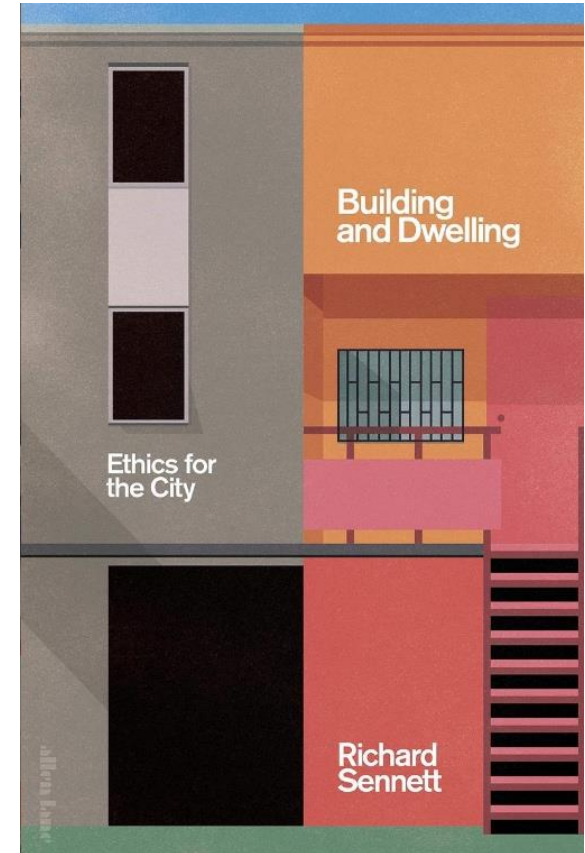
The urban experience, 2019

Tension between "building" (the physical construction of cities) and "dwelling" (how people experience and live in them) is crucial to understanding the challenges of urban life.

To create better cities, we must balance the technical and design aspects of urban planning with the lived, human experiences of those who inhabit them

A city is “a human settlement in which strangers are likely to meet”

Cities should have public spaces where city dwellers can acquire urban competence by learning to socialize with strangers



The urban as processes and relations

...cities are barely physical entities, but a theoretical category developed in order to put forward an argument on general transformations of the societies of which they are a part.

For key thinkers, cities were theoretical constructs through which major societal dynamics could be studied (Berndt 2015)

Authors	Concept of the Urban
Marx and Engels	'Great Towns' as the sites of industrialization, and thus of the formation of a contradiction between the modern bourgeoisie and the proletariat.
Simmel	Big cities as arenas of an emerging metropolitan mentality, resulting from tensions between individuality and rationalization and the need to interact with large numbers of people.
Weber	(Occidental) cities as (1) the site of a replacement of traditional communities, (2) as market centres, and (3) as civic political unities, with corporate political bodies having significant powers over their territory.
Wirth	The city as 'a way of life', marked by social disintegration, as well as utilitarianism and efficiency. Moreover, density and heterogeneity lead people to live in homogenous groups resulting in a typically urban 'mosaic of social worlds'.
Castells	Cities as the sites of 'collective consumption' and urban social movements which organize around 'collective consumption use value'.
Harvey	The built environment as the site of investment, disinvestment and reinvestment cycles which are crucial to the reproduction of capital. This results in a system of 'uneven development' in which urban spaces are continuously remade by new rounds of 'spatial fixes'.



How would you define “the urban”?

What is the urban?

If you stand naked on the front porch and the neighbors can't see you...

.... It's rural

If you stand naked on the front porch and the neighbors call the cops on you...

.... It's suburban

If you stand naked on the front porch and the neighbours ignore you...

.... It's urban

Ilmonen 2016: The Changing Urban Question

First Urbanism

The Industrial City

Working class

Homogeneous population

The Housing Question

City as a problem, the negative

"Other" (vs. Country)

Social stability and welfare (state)

Nation state

Socialdemocratic welfare policy

Second Urbanism

The Post Industrial City

Mobile middle classes

Differentiating population

Urban renaissance

Positive urbanism

Competitiveness, also welfare subject to competition

Global world

Neoliberal market policy

TOP JOURNALS



Scimago

<https://www.scimagojr.com> » Journalrank

	Title	Type	↓ SJR	H Index	Total Docs. (2024)	Total Docs. (3years)	Total Refs. (2024)	Total Citations (3years)	Citable Docs. (3years)	Citations / Doc. (2years)	Ref. / Doc. (2024)												
1	Nature Sustainability	Journal	7.292	146	228	596	9608	11969	435	17.96	42.14	11	Urban Climate	view journal details	1.563	88	467	995	32656	7827	993	7.82	69.93
2	Journal of Urban Economics	Journal	3.854	139	66	174	3421	1124	170	5.18	51.83	12	Journal of the American Planning Association	Journal	1.508	119	80	153	4608	675	124	3.96	57.60
3	Landscape and Urban Planning	Journal	2.932	229	183	639	13658	7330	638	10.48	74.63	13	Housing Studies	Journal	1.496	95	213	257	14687	1402	251	5.09	68.95
4	Computers, Environment and Urban Systems	Journal	2.523	118	99	312	6496	3455	312	9.64	65.62	14	Urban Geography	Journal	1.419	96	149	303	10102	1432	293	4.29	67.80
5	Urban Studies	Journal	1.980	183	225	535	14925	3389	525	5.76	66.33	15	International Journal of Urban and Regional Research	Journal	1.417	138	59	194	4235	721	192	3.08	71.78
6	Regional Science and Urban Economics	Journal	1.917	101	60	213	3541	952	210	3.48	59.02	16	Housing Policy Debate	Journal	1.405	78	89	204	4806	780	172	3.59	54.00
7	Urban Education	Journal	1.882	76	151	236	10409	881	236	3.89	68.93	17	Smart Cities	Journal	1.398	42	153	319	11272	3391	317	7.92	73.67
8	Cities	Journal	1.839	141	759	1376	57691	11736	1369	7.82	76.01	18	Urban Review	Journal	1.223	59	49	94	3210	312	93	2.95	65.51
9	Habitat International	Journal	1.837	127	167	396	12516	3360	395	7.99	74.95	19	Journal of Race Ethnicity and the City	Journal	1.220	9	16	29	1220	112	27	1.58	76.25
10	Journal of Urban Health	Journal	1.653	114	132	291	5202	1349	264	4.53	39.41	20	Housing, Theory and Society	Journal	1.194	60	56	101	3243	434	100	3.28	57.91



Aalto University

Urban studies

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Urban studies

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Kim Dovey , Elek Pafka 

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[Urbanizing degrowth: Five steps towards a Radical Spatial Degrowth Agenda for planning in the face of climate emergency](#)

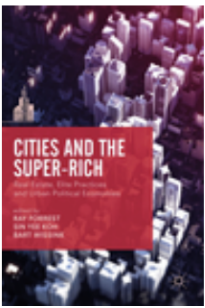
Maria Kaika , Angelos Varvarousis , Federico Demaria , Hug March 

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[Why does everyone think cities can save the planet?](#)

Hillary Angelo , David Wachsmuth

- ***City & Community*** advances urban sociological theory, promotes the highest quality empirical research on communities and urban social life, and encourages sociological perspectives on urban policy. It is the journal of the Community and Urban Sociology Section of the American Sociological Association.
- <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/journal/15406040>

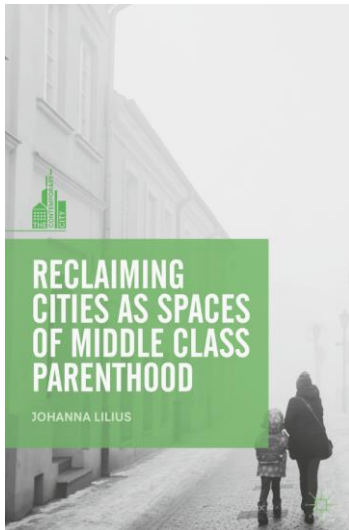


The Contemporary City

palgrave
macmillan

Forrest, R. (Ed), Ronald, R. (Ed)

In recent decades cities have been variously impacted by neoliberalism, economic crises, climate change, industrialization and post-industrialization and widening inequalities. So what is it like to live in these contemporary cities? What are the key drivers shaping cities and neighborhoods? To what extent are people being bound together or driven apart? How do these factors vary cross-culturally and cross nationally? This book series aims to explore the various aspects of the contemporary urban experience from a firmly interdisciplinary and international perspective. With editors based in Amsterdam and Hong Kong, the series is drawn on an axis between old and new cities in the West and East.



For nearly a century families have been out-migrating to suburbs and peri-urban areas. In this book, Johanna Lilius conceptualizes the relatively recent phenomenon of families choosing to live in the inner city. Drawing on a range of qualitative data, the book offers a holistic approach to simultaneously understanding changes within parenting practices and changes connected to city development. The book explains not only why families choose to stay in the inner city and how they use the city in their everyday lives, but also how families change the landscape of contemporary cities, and how the family is, and has been, perceived in urban planning and policy-making. The Nordic perspective provided by Lilius makes this book an important contribution in helping understand inner city change outside the Anglo-American context, and will appeal to an international audience.

Working methods on the course

- 13.1 Introduction to urban studies
- 20.1 Housing
- 27.1 Segregation (with Dr Katriina Rosengren)
- 3.2 Gentrification
- 10.2. Presentations

If you have to be absent from any of the classes, please provide a 2 page essay based on two readings/lecture (send by email to Johanna.lilius@aalto.fi)

Working methods on the course

- Readings + discussion + essay
- Readings:
 - Minimum of three people choose the same article according to their interests.
 - During class discussion about the article with those who read the same (20-30 min), ending up with a short summary to be presented for the whole class

Essay

In your essay, discuss how a phenomenon you find interesting in your city such as begging, air b n b, a specific building, parkour, homelessness, new food consumption spaces, demographic changes, gendered spaces (these are examples, feel free to be creative) relates to one or several concepts used in urban studies (those that we have covered during the course or any that we were unable to cover). Explore the policy implications of that phenomenon for planning, and discuss how policies are working in order to strengthen or weaken the phenomenon. If there are no policy implications, discuss why you think that is.

Essay examples

- Private Art Funding in Finland and Global Gentrification Processes - Case Study of Kone Foundation
 - Beyond 'the Gay Index': The multifaceted role of the LGBT population in gentrification processes
 - The role of public spaces in fostering equality in democracy and civic activism
 - Provision of Educational Services for the Elderly in Moscow by District, and its significance in ageing policies context.
 - Shopping centers, the center for the public? An exploration of the Iso Omena shopping center in Espoo
 - Development of Bike-sharing Systems in Milan: the contribution to urban mobility and livability of the city
 - Municipal Strategies and Development of Real Estate sector in Helsinki
 - Regulating short-term renting in Finland
 - Denmark's ghettos. A framework for integration or alienation
-

Essay examples

- Temporary uses of urban spaces and urban mobility
- Helsinki City Boulevards: A contested case of infill development
- Finnish Densification Policies: Increased Accessibility, Increased Segregation?
- Car-centric Urban Planning VS. Walkable City: effects on the residents and urban landscape
- PLANNING AFTER DEATH: Cemeteries As Sites of Contested Belongingness.
- Lapland tourism, gentrification variations and indigenous Sámi people
- Homelessness and the Public Space
- How Helsinki Central Library Oodi meets the concerns of publicity of a public space and increasing segregation of the city?
- Compromising The Small Scale for City Image - An Evaluation of Tripla and Pasila's 2019-2040 Developments

Essay

Requirements

The length of the essay should be max 7 pages (times new roman, spacing 1,15). Write concisely!

Start with a brief introduction to your topic

Organize your text under several subtitles

Present your case well

End your essay with conclusions and a discussion

Find at least three new articles (or books, books chapters) that we haven't read during the course to use in your essay.

References

Essay

Deadlines

Remember to start working early enough!

Deadlines

Remember to start working early enough!

By 20.1 Send an email to Johanna (johanna.lilius@aalto.fi) in which you briefly explain the idea of your essay

By 9.2 (morning) hand in essay draft which gives your evaluator a fair chance to assess your work

10.2 present your essay, and give peer feedback to the peer assigned to you (the assigning will be done after 20.1),

By 12.2 give written feedback to the peer assigned to you, and using the rubric, give your peer a preliminary grade. Upload the comments in your own submission field (you will end the course with three submission in your “folder”: your essay draft, comments on another essay and your final essay)

By 24.2 hand in the final essay

Do not hesitate to discuss your idea for the essay by email Johanna.lilius@aalto.fi before 20.1, or during the sessions!

	Grade 5	Grade 4	Grade 3	Grade 2	Grade 1
Introduction	The introduction is engaging and inviting, states the topic and previews the structure of the essay.	The introduction states the topic and previews the structure of the essay.	The introduction states the main topic, but does not adequately preview the structure of the essay.	The introduction fails to engage and is unfocused. The structure of the essay is unclear.	There is no clear and the structure of the essay is missing.
Grasp of reading(s)	Essay represents the authors' arguments, evidence and conclusions accurately, fairly and eloquently. Demonstrates a firm understanding of the implications of the author's arguments.	Essay represents the author's arguments, evidence and conclusions accurately.	Essay represents the authors' arguments, evidence and conclusions accurately though not sufficiently clearly. There are minor inaccuracies.	Essay represents the authors' arguments, evidence and conclusions in an unclear manner. There are major inaccuracies.	Essay badly misrepresents the authors' arguments, evidence, and/or conclusions.
Depth of analysis	Essay goes beyond the assignment to explore the implications of a phenomenon in particularly thoughtful, insightful, and/or original ways.	Essay fully meets the parameters of the assignment, but does not exceed them.	Essay addresses some aspects of the assignment, but the engagement is not sufficient.	Essay does not address some aspects of the assignment.	Essay does not address the assignment.
Evidence	Evidence used to support the central point is rich, detailed and well chosen. The connection between argument and evidence is clearly and compellingly articulated in all cases. Opposing evidence (i.e. evidence that might seem to contradict your argument) is considered and convincingly refuted.	Evidence used to support the central point is well chosen, though not rich or detailed. The connection between argument and evidence is clearly articulated. Some opposing evidence is considered and refuted.	Connection between argument and evidence is not clearly articulated. Consideration of opposing evidence is cursory or the evidence is not convincingly refuted.	Evidence used does not clearly support the main argument. Important opposing evidence is ignored, thereby weakening the central argument.	Evidence is missing
Conclusion	Synthesizes and reframes key points from the essay. Suggests new perspectives or questions relevant to the central argument, and brings closure.	Synthesizes and brings closure, but does not examine new perspectives or questions adequately.	Restates the same points as the topic paragraph without reframing them. Introduces new material rather than new perspectives.	Repeats the topic paragraph more-or-less verbatim.	Is missing or cursory.
Organization	Organization of essay as a whole is logical and quickly apparent. Connections among paragraphs are clearly articulated. Transitions between paragraphs are smooth.	Organization of essay as a whole is logical and apparent, but transitions between paragraphs are not consistently smooth.	Organization of the essay as a whole is to some extent incoherent. Not all parts of the essay fit the organizational structure.	Organization of the essay as a whole can only be discerned with effort.	Organization of the essay as a whole is not logical or discernable.
Clarity	Throughout the essay, wording is precise and unambiguous. Sentence structure is consistently clear and lucid. References are consistent.	Essay is for the most part precisely worded and unambiguous. Sentence structure is mostly clear. References are consistent.	Wording is imprecise or ambiguous fairly often. Sentence structure is fairly often clear. References are consistent.	Wording is often imprecise or ambiguous. Sentence structure is often confusing. References are consistent.	Throughout the essay, wording is imprecise or ambiguous. Sentence structure is consistently confusing. References are inconsistent.

HOUSING/DWELLING/RESIDING

Readings

1. Ilmonen, M. (2016). On Housing Preferences and Housing Choices. In Gromark, S; M. Ilmonen; E. Stoa; K. Paadam (eds). *Ways of Residing in Transformation Interdisciplinary Perspectives*, pp. 35–56. England and the United States: Ashgate.
2. Ronald, R.; J. Kadi (2017): The Revival of Private Landlords in Britain's Post-Homeownership Society, *New Political Economy* 2017 (6), 786-803.
3. Kern, L. (2007) Reshaping the Boundaries of Public and Private Life: Gender, Condominium Development, and the Neoliberalization of Urban Living, *Urban Geography*, 28:7, pp. 657-681
4. Lilius, J., & Hirvonen, J. (2023). The changing position of housing estate neighbourhoods in the Helsinki Metropolitan Area. *Journal of Housing and the Built Environment*, 38, pp. 121–140.
5. Hannu Ruonavaara (2025) An idea that refuses to die. Rise, fall and resurgence of “housing class”, *Housing Studies*, 40:11, pp. 2507-2527

TASK: Find at least one policy document related to the provided literature. Be prepared to introduce and discuss it in class.